being killed by a one-tusked elephant. Nainsukh was promptly identified, as was his mahout Somnath, now brought out to tell his story.

'I am a great leader, take me alive to the king and you will get a great reward,' Ali Quli had yelled.[87]

Whether it was because he did not recognize Ali Quli, or because Somnath's blood was in as much of a boil from battle as that of the elephants he drove, the mahout paid no heed. He drove Nainsukh forward, step by heavy step. The elephant knew what to do. He crushed Ali Quli 'with its trunk and feet', writes Badauni, '. . . and made his body like a bag full of chess-pieces'.

Akbar wanted proof; he wanted Ali Quli's head. A gold coin, he declared, for anyone who brought him the trophy – and a rupee, to boot, for every Hindustani head besides. 'The crowd ran off' on their grim treasure hunt;[88] and one by one the heads began to roll in, each to be inspected for signs of Ali Quli's features.

It wasn't only soldiers who went head-collecting, but all the many types of people who marched with an army: accountants, cooks, painters. It was a clerk who found Ali Quli's broken body. He was sauntering back to claim his gold when he came across a slave. Perhaps they knew each other; perhaps the clerk was unwise enough to boast of his find. At any rate, the slave quickly divested the clerk of his prize and brought it to Akbar, claiming to have found the head under a tree.

But now, another problem arose. A man crushed by an elephant does not retain his looks. Yes, this head seemed to match Ali Quli's, but how to be sure?

Badauni writes that a former eunuch of Ali Quli's stepped forward, describing how his late master's habit of chewing paan had blackened the teeth on his right side. Thus, the mutilated head passed from hand to hand, its jaws examined by appraising eyes. It was Ali Quli's vakil, a minor raja, according to Badauni, who took the head in his hands and identified it with cries of 'Alas! Alas!'

Alas, indeed, for the Uzbek of melting heart and strong arm; the warlord who would wait upon a lover as his slave, but would defer to no man as his emperor; alas for Ali Quli, as he faded from the pages of history, his bid for power as ill-fated as his pursuit of love.

. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories), vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe